

MAYBEWELL BOOKS 

Story Starters

Sixty first lines, last lines, and impossible situations

A CREATIVITY BOOK

the middle is yours.

maybewarellbooks.com

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Welcome, Writer

Every page in this book gives you a piece of a story that doesn't exist yet. Some pages start it. Some pages end it. Some pages just hand you a very strange situation and get out of the way.

There's no wrong way to fill the space below a prompt. Some pages have lines. Some are blank on purpose — a story doesn't have to be sentences. It can be a list, a drawing, a diagram, a mess.

Turn to the back for three story openings that need an ending.

20 PROMPTS · FIRST LINES

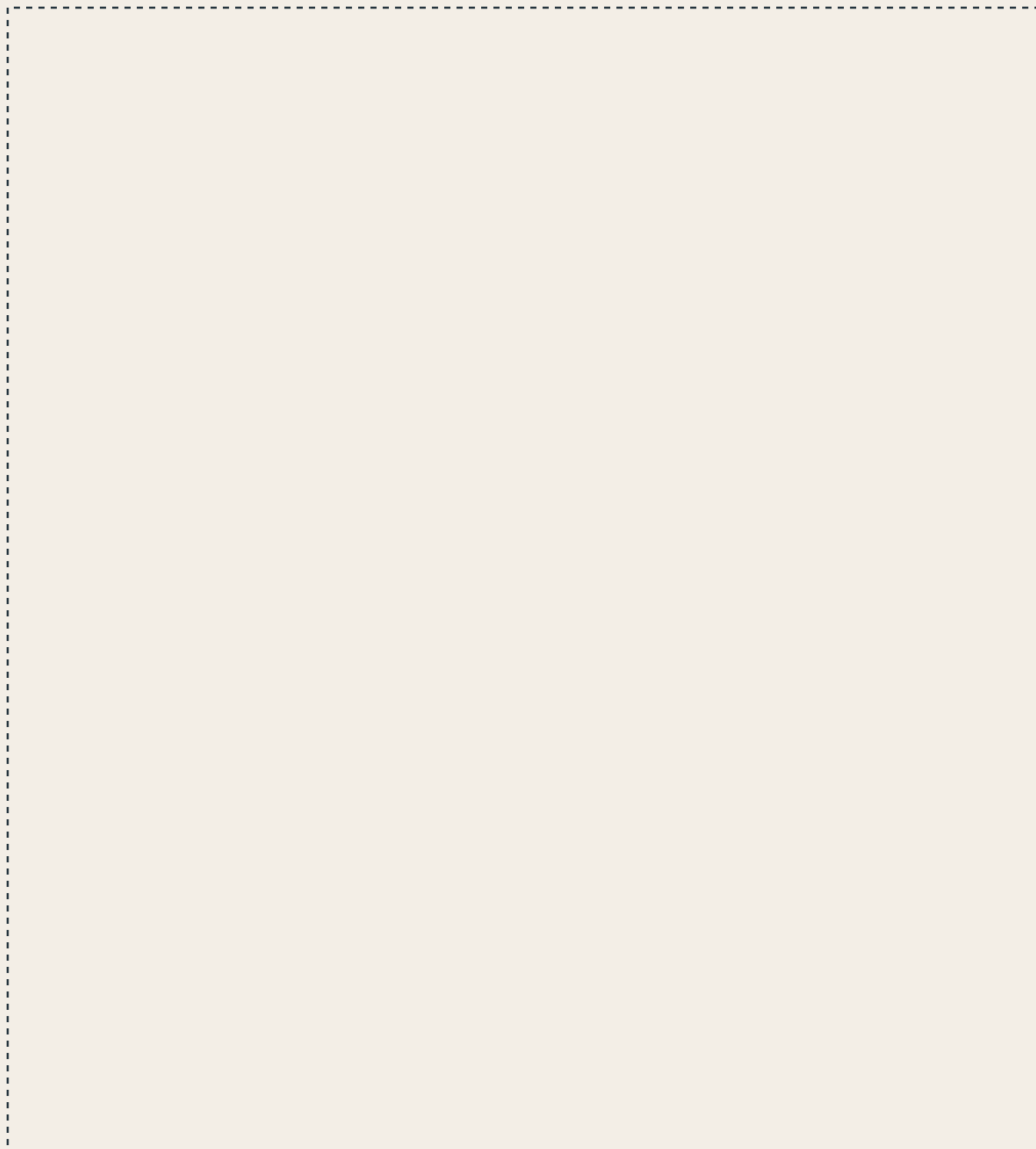
FIRST LINES

Start here. Write what happens next.

The letter had been sitting in the mailbox for eleven years before anyone noticed the stamp was from the future.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

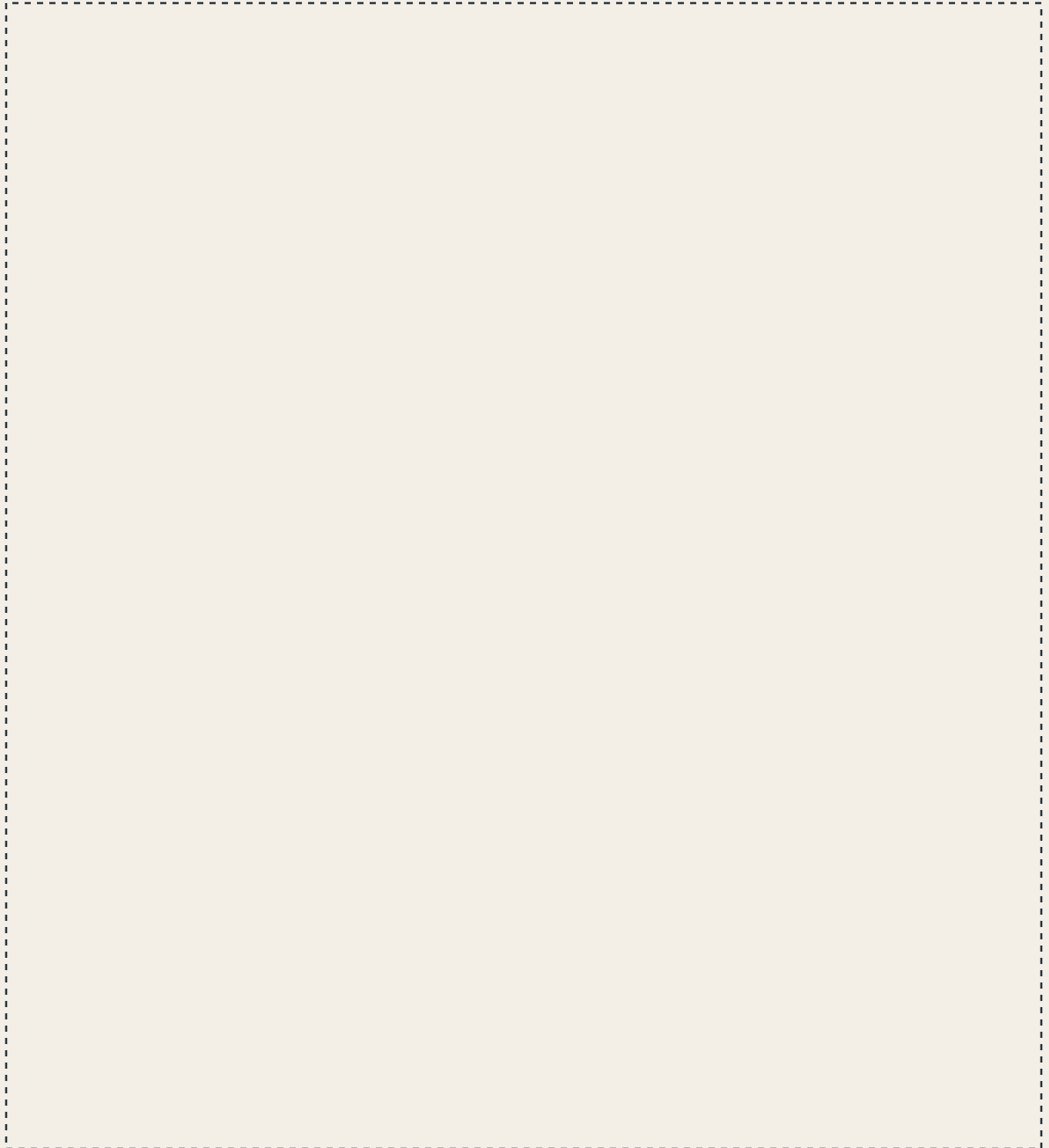
Nobody in the village would admit to owning the goat, but everyone agreed it knew too much.



By the time the lighthouse keeper realized the storm wasn't a storm, the boats were already gone.

[illegible]

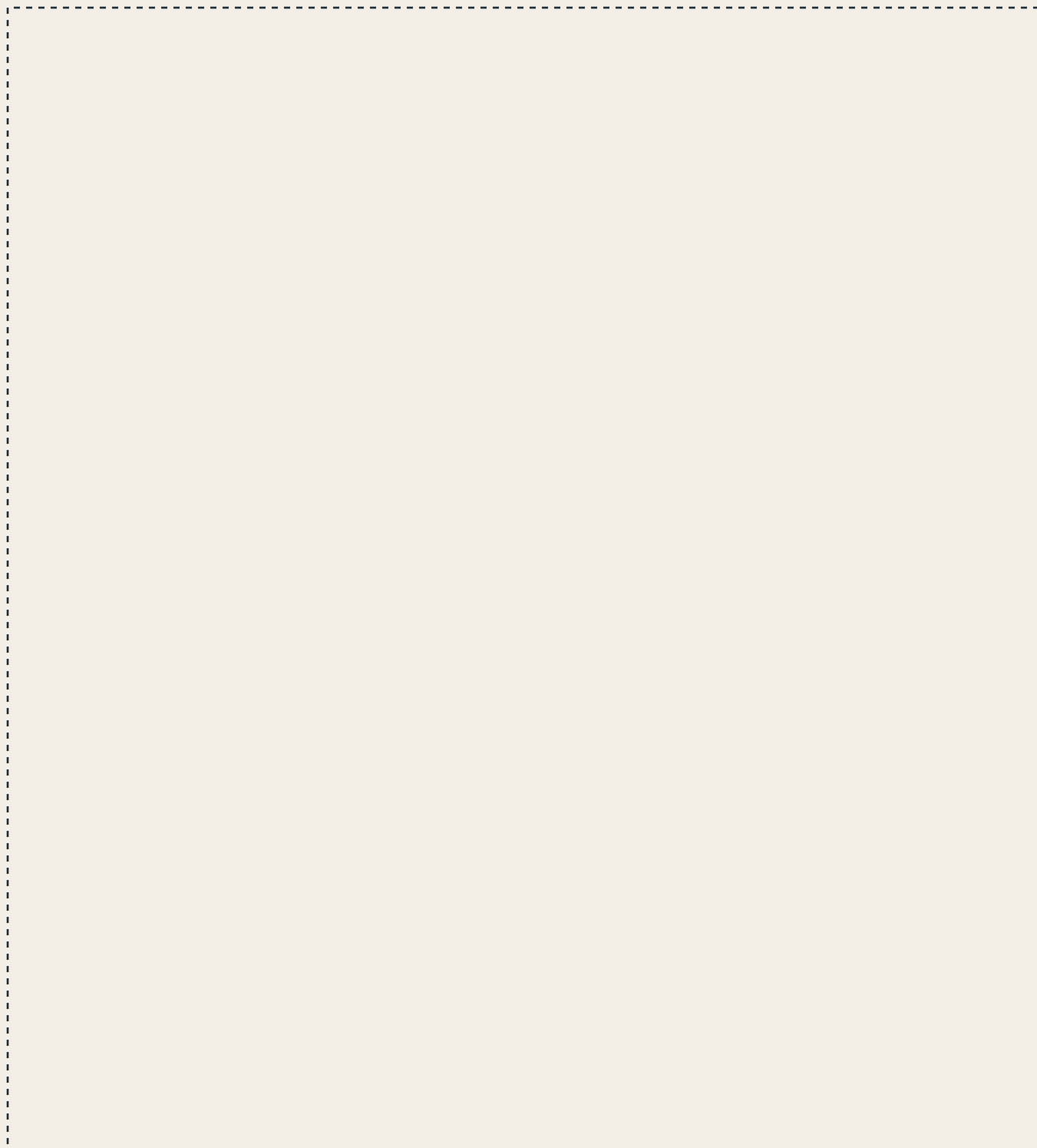
The new kid could turn invisible, but only when nobody was looking, which made it very hard to prove.



Grandma's attic had exactly one door too many.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

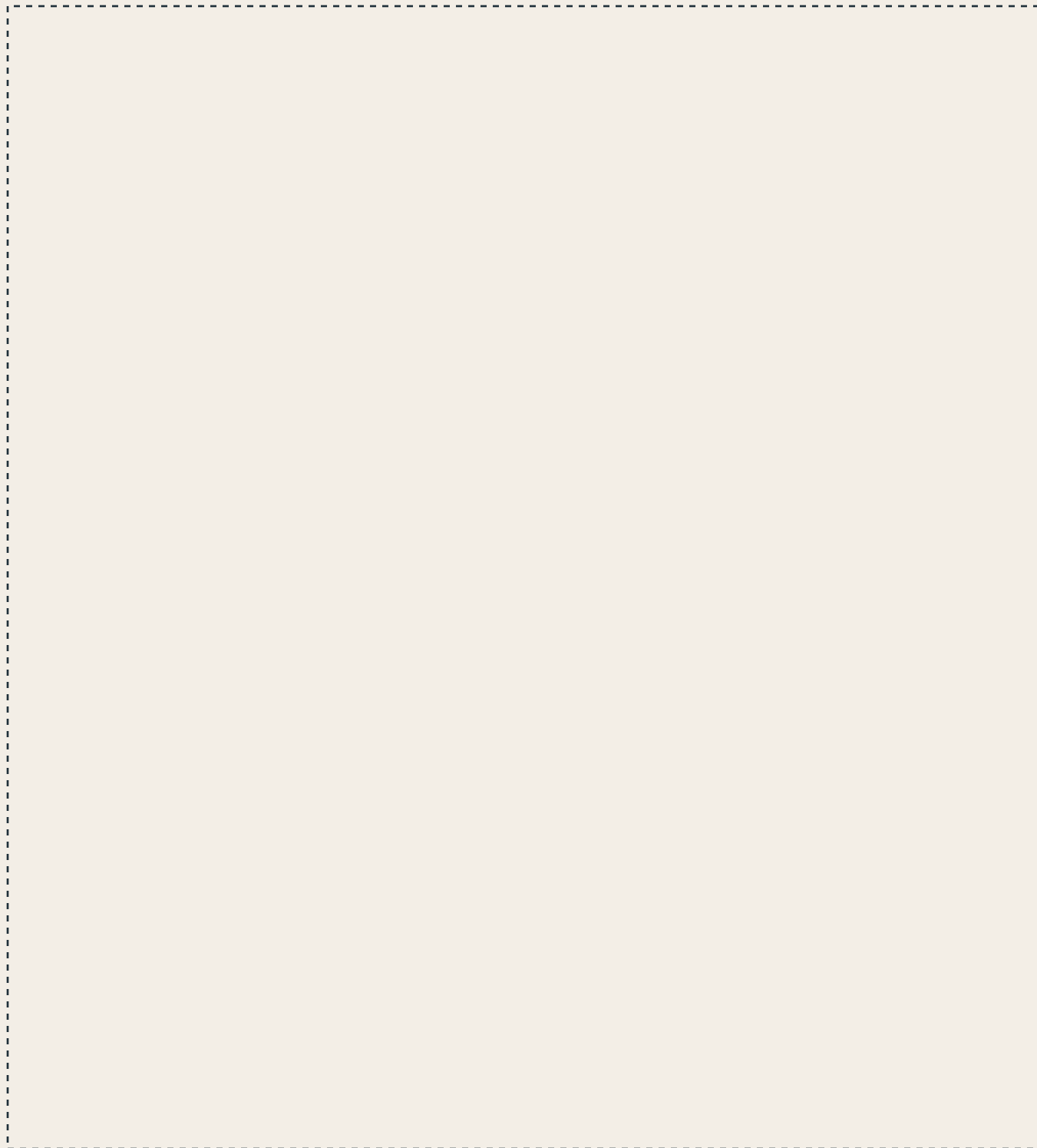
The recipe called for one tear, freely given, and Mira had been saving hers for weeks.



Every clock in the house stopped at 3:14, and only the dog seemed to know why.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

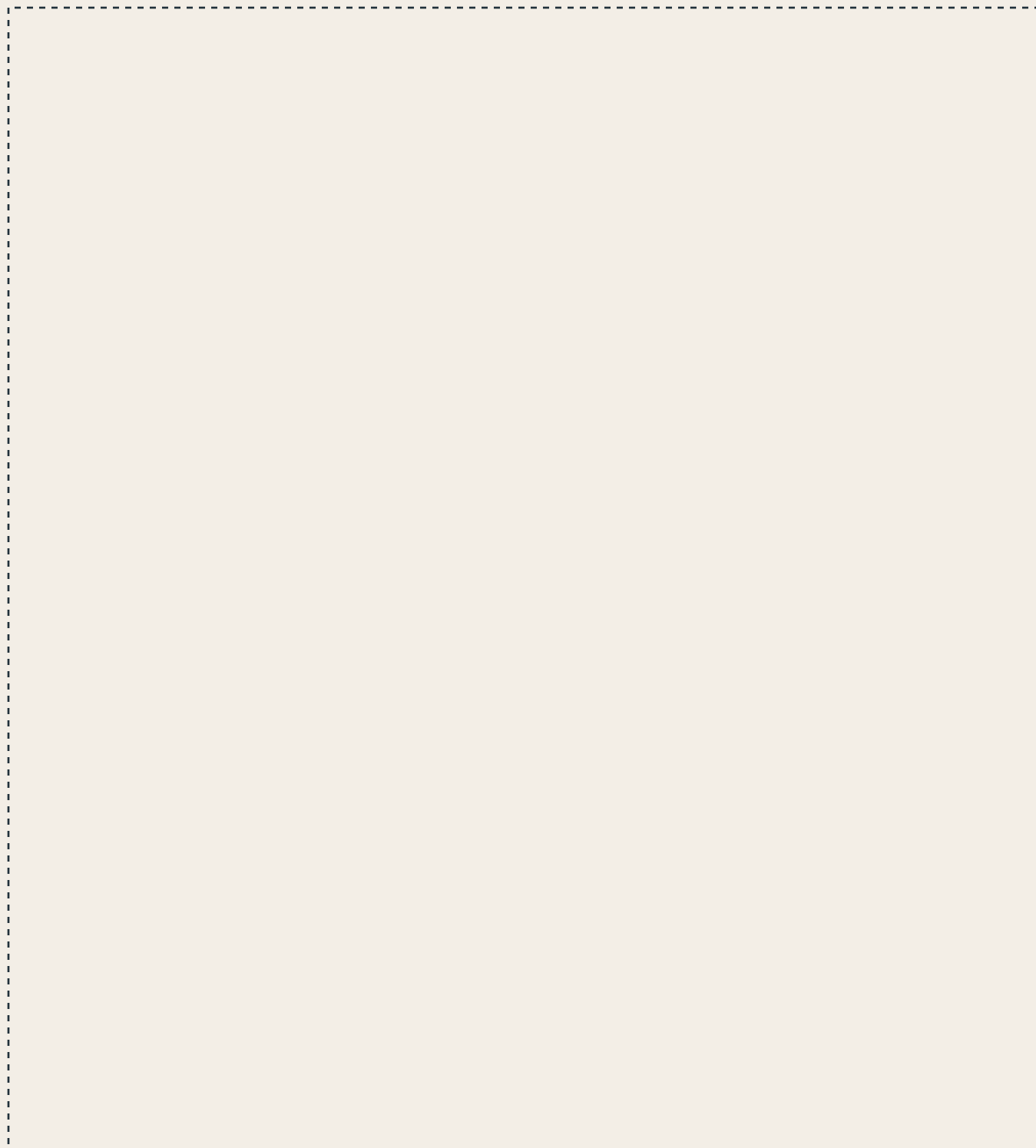
The map was drawn on the back of someone's hand, and the hand was still attached.



It rained fish on a Tuesday, and by Thursday people had mostly stopped talking about it.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

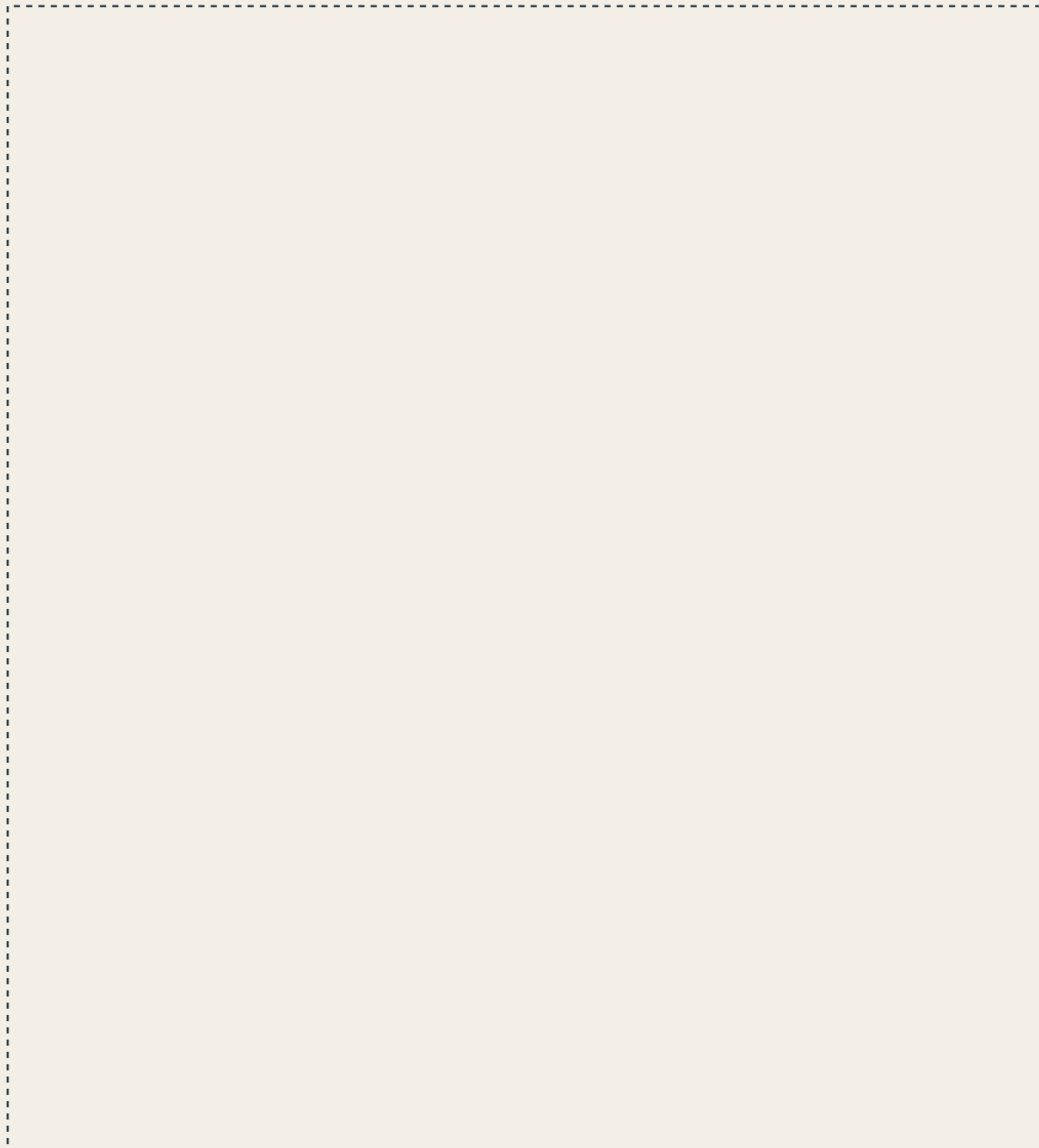
The last dragon in the world worked at the library, three days a week, mostly reshelving.



Somebody had replaced all the streetlights with tiny, unimpressed moons.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

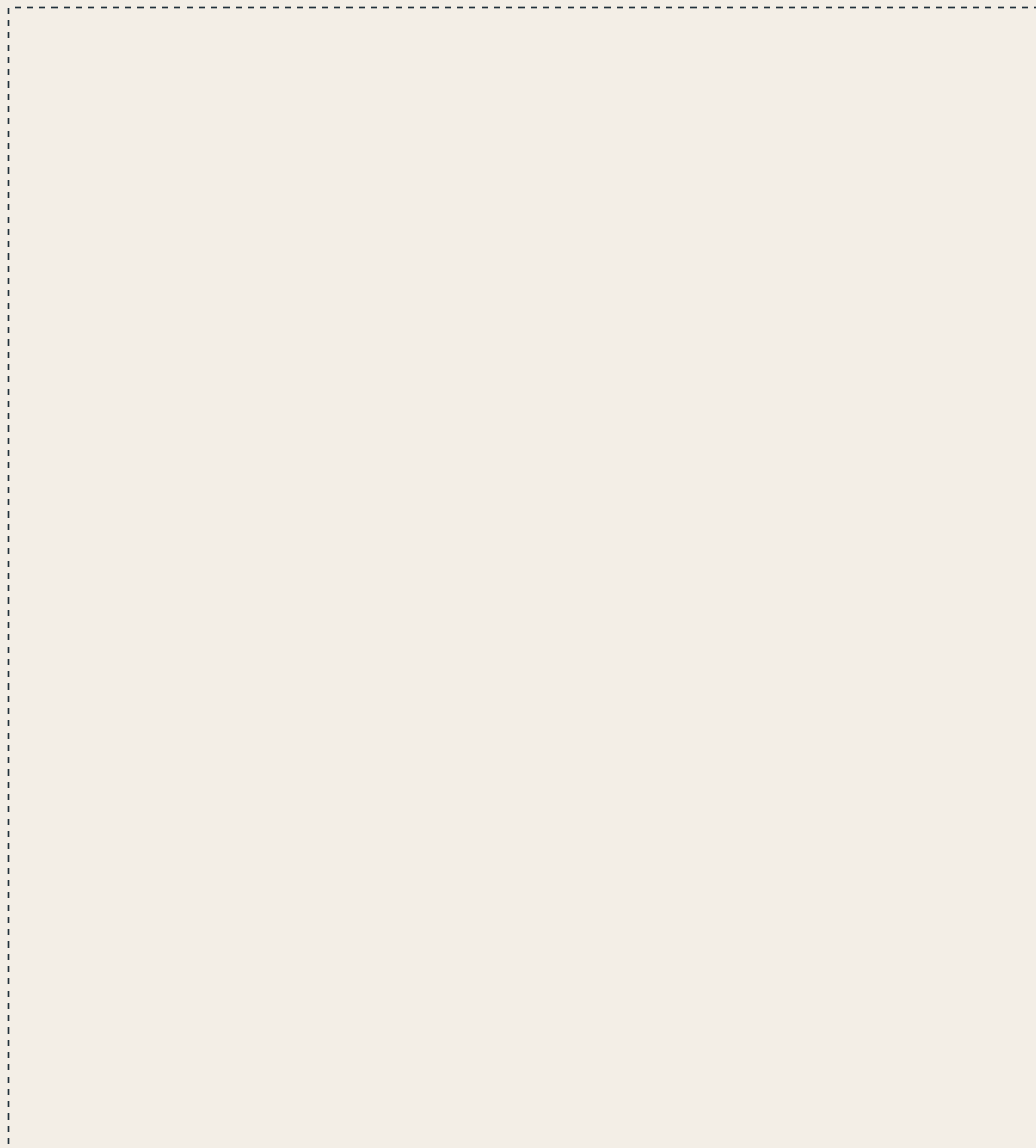
**The submarine surfaced in the middle of a wheat field,
forty miles from any ocean.**



Every year on her birthday, a single word appeared carved into the oldest tree in town.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

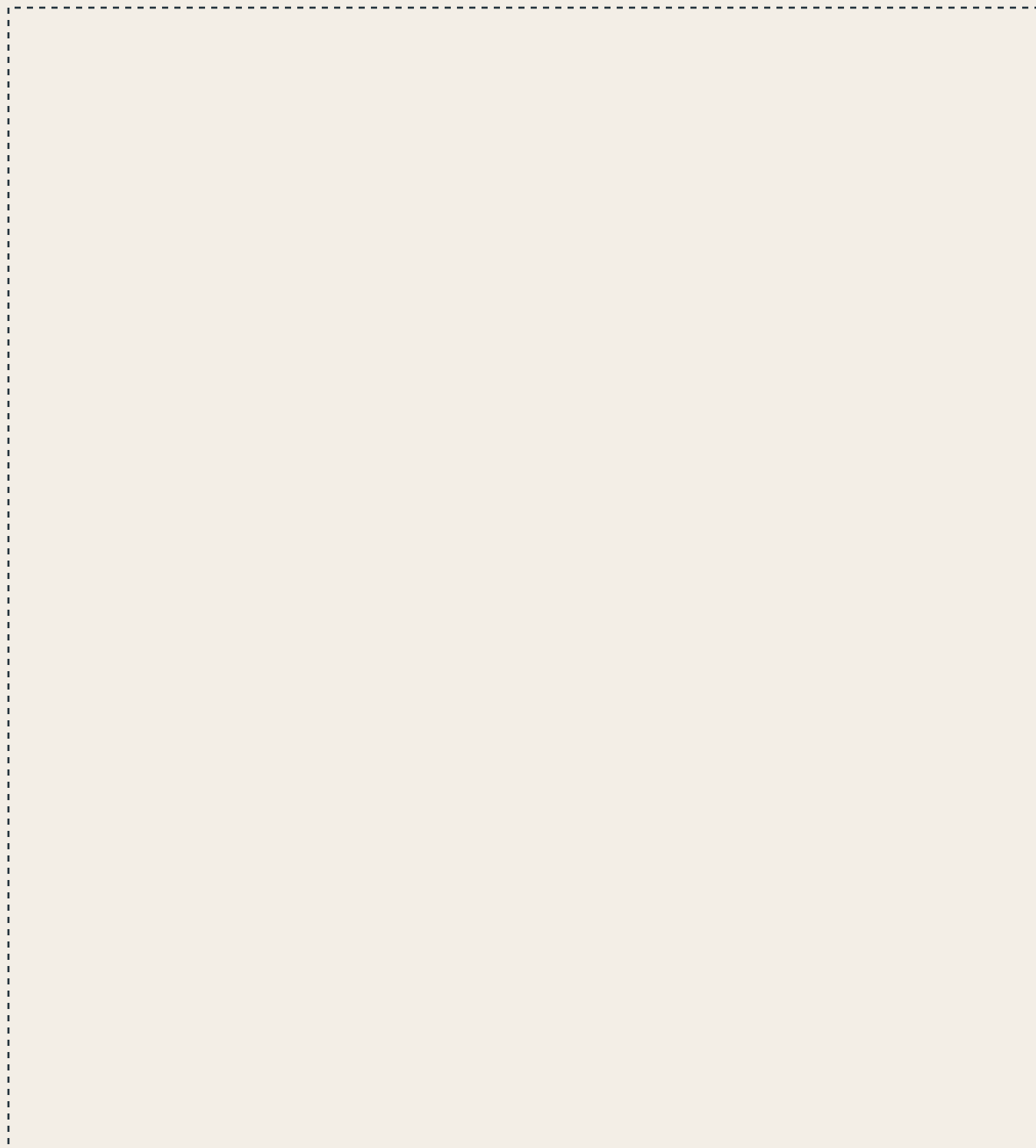
The vending machine only accepted coins that hadn't been minted yet.



Two minutes before the wedding, the groom remembered he'd left himself a note somewhere important.

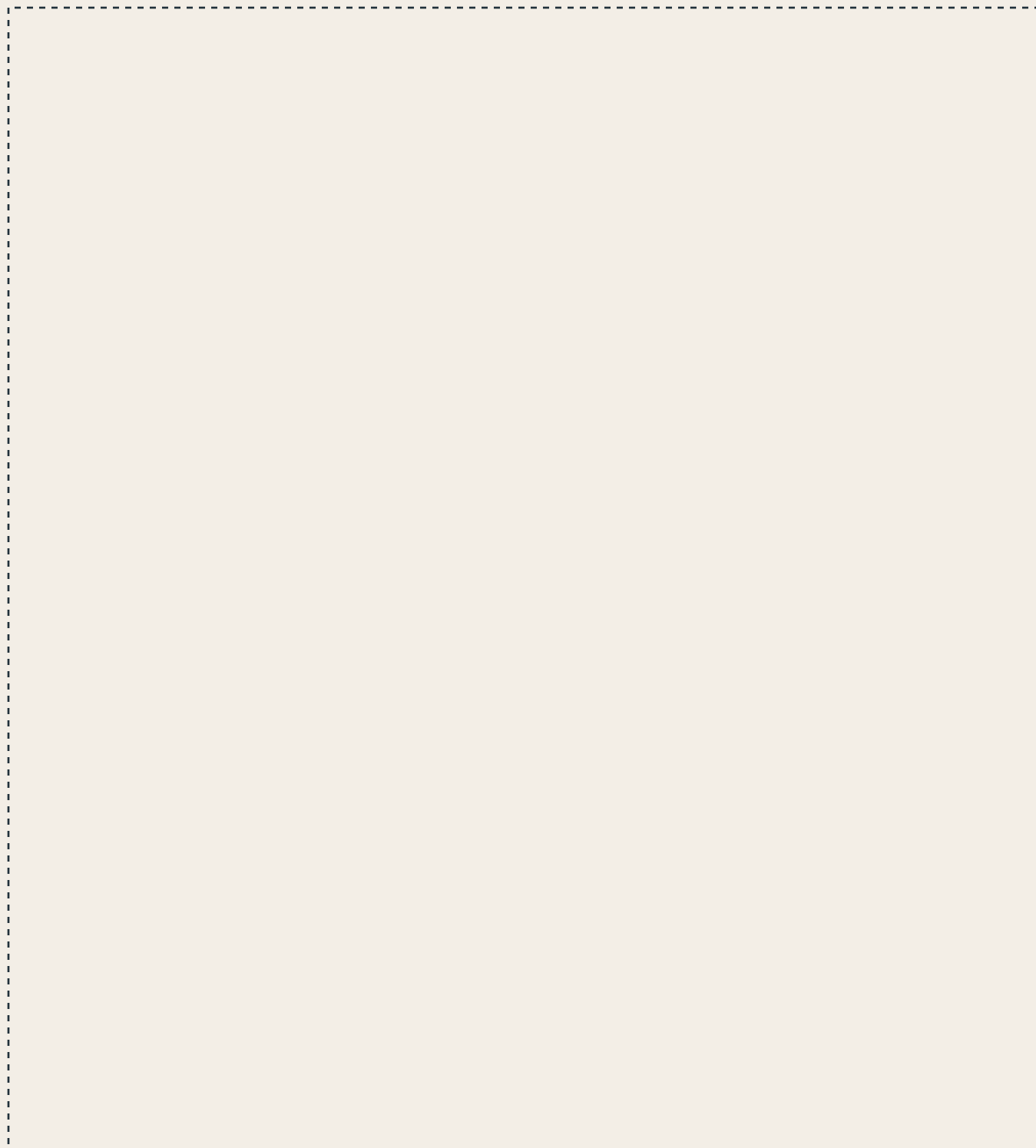
[illegible]

The dog next door had started giving directions, and they were always right.



When the museum closed for renovations, nobody thought to ask the paintings how they felt about it.

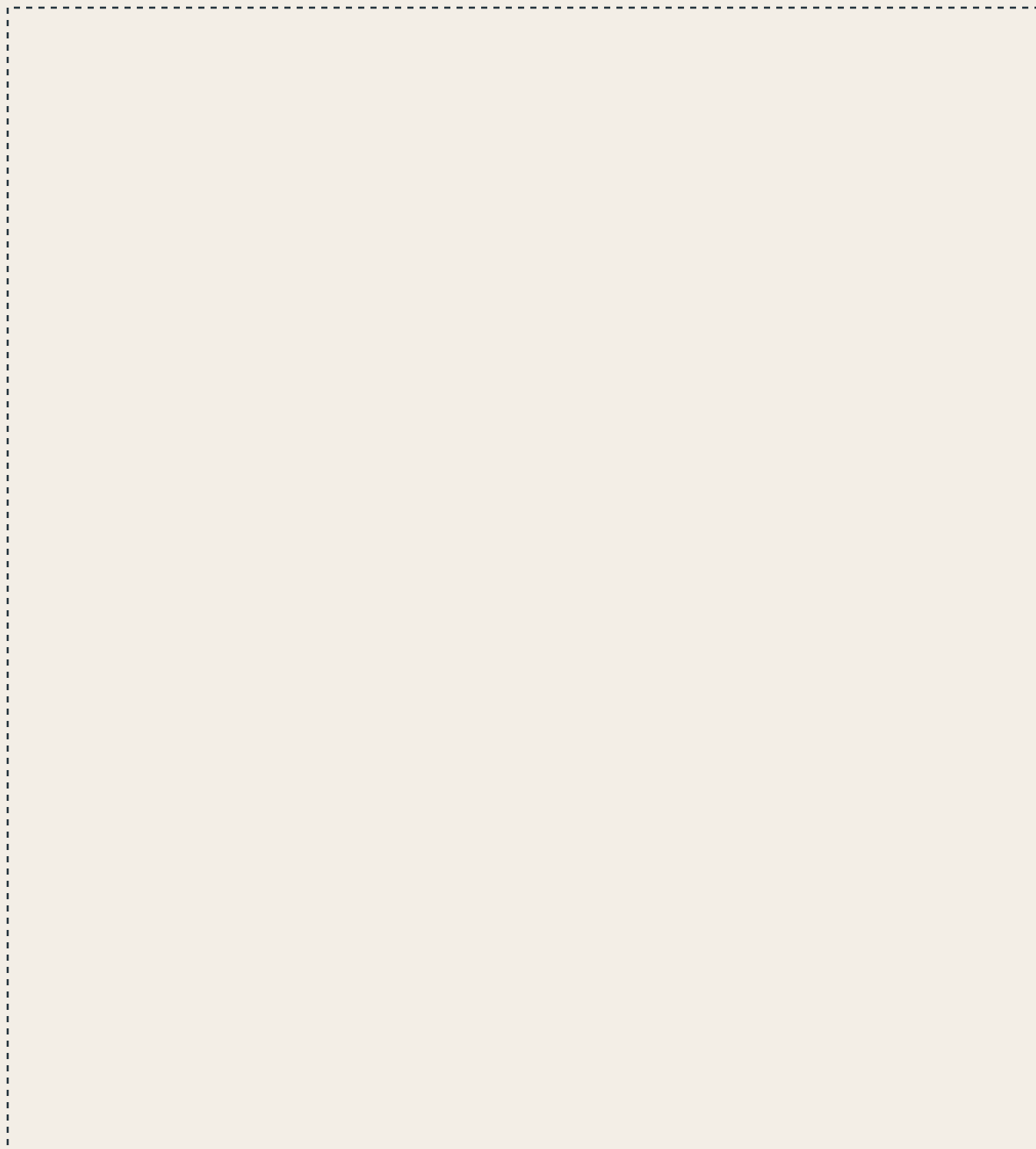
The new house came with a basement that hadn't existed the day before.



Somewhere in the school, a locker was quietly filling up with snow.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

The photograph looked normal until you noticed the shadow belonged to someone else.



20 PROMPTS · LAST LINES

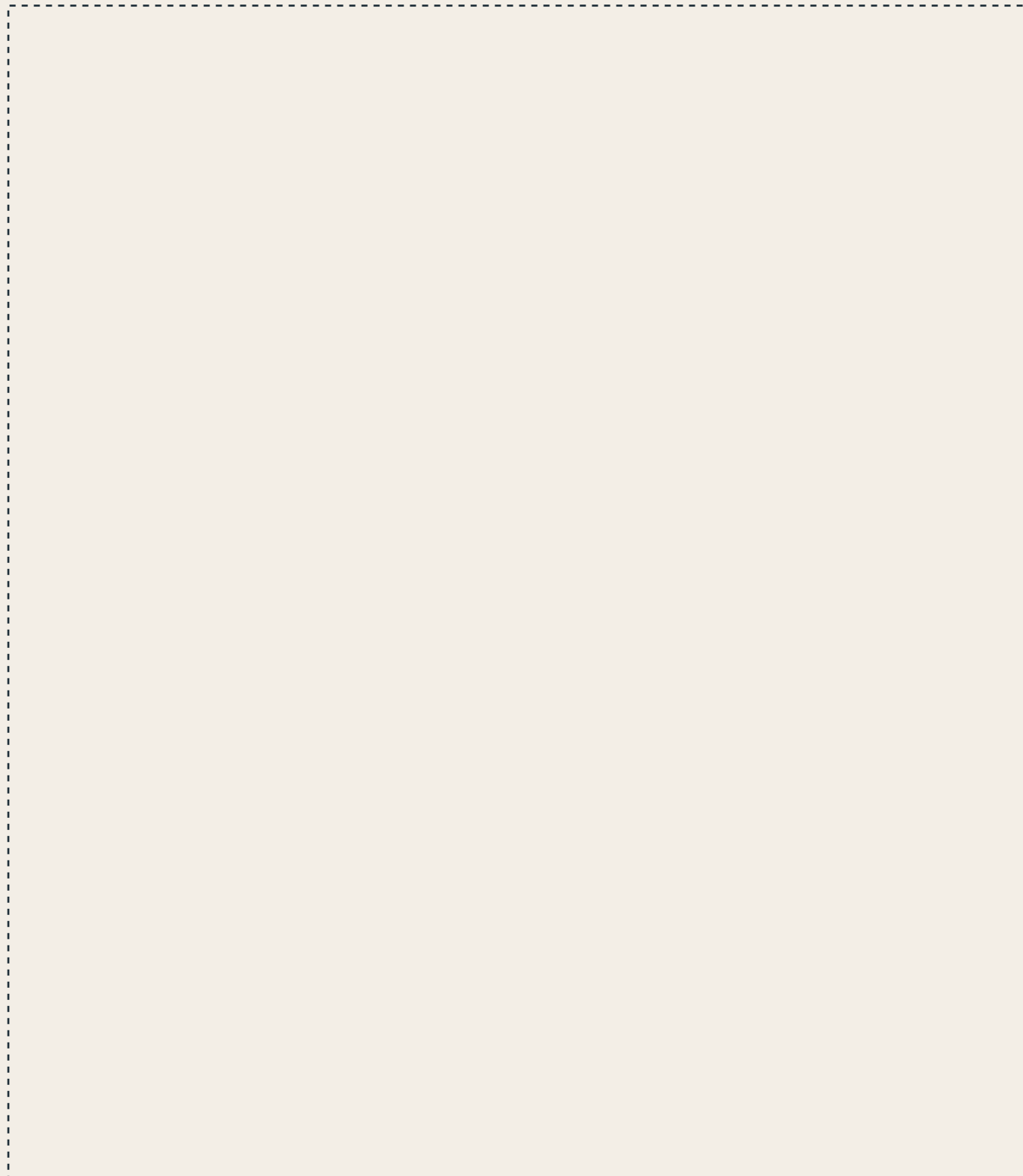
LAST LINES

Work backward. What led here?

...and that is the real reason nobody in our family owns an umbrella.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

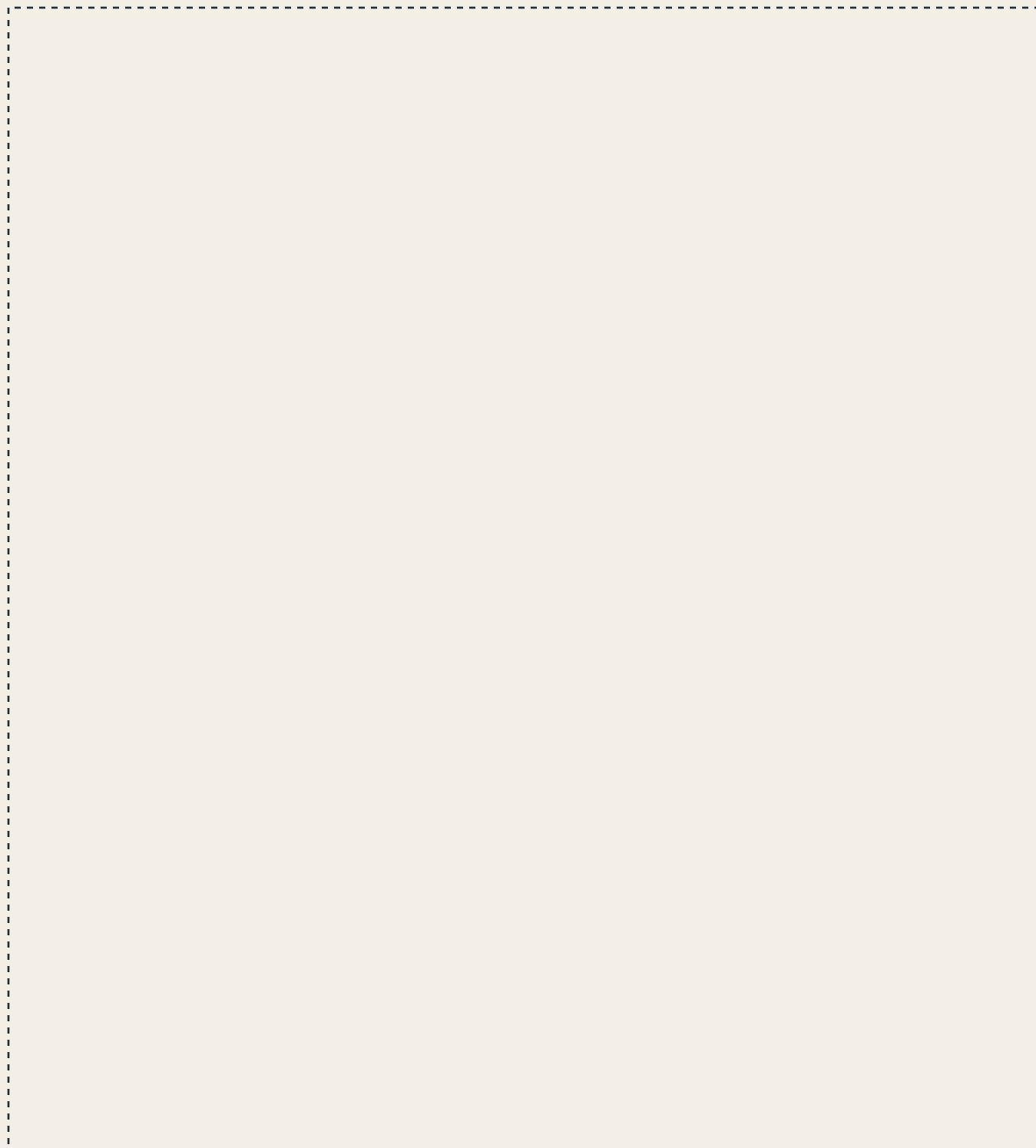
...which explains the raccoon, but not the crown.



...so the two of them agreed never to mention the door again, and mostly kept that promise.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

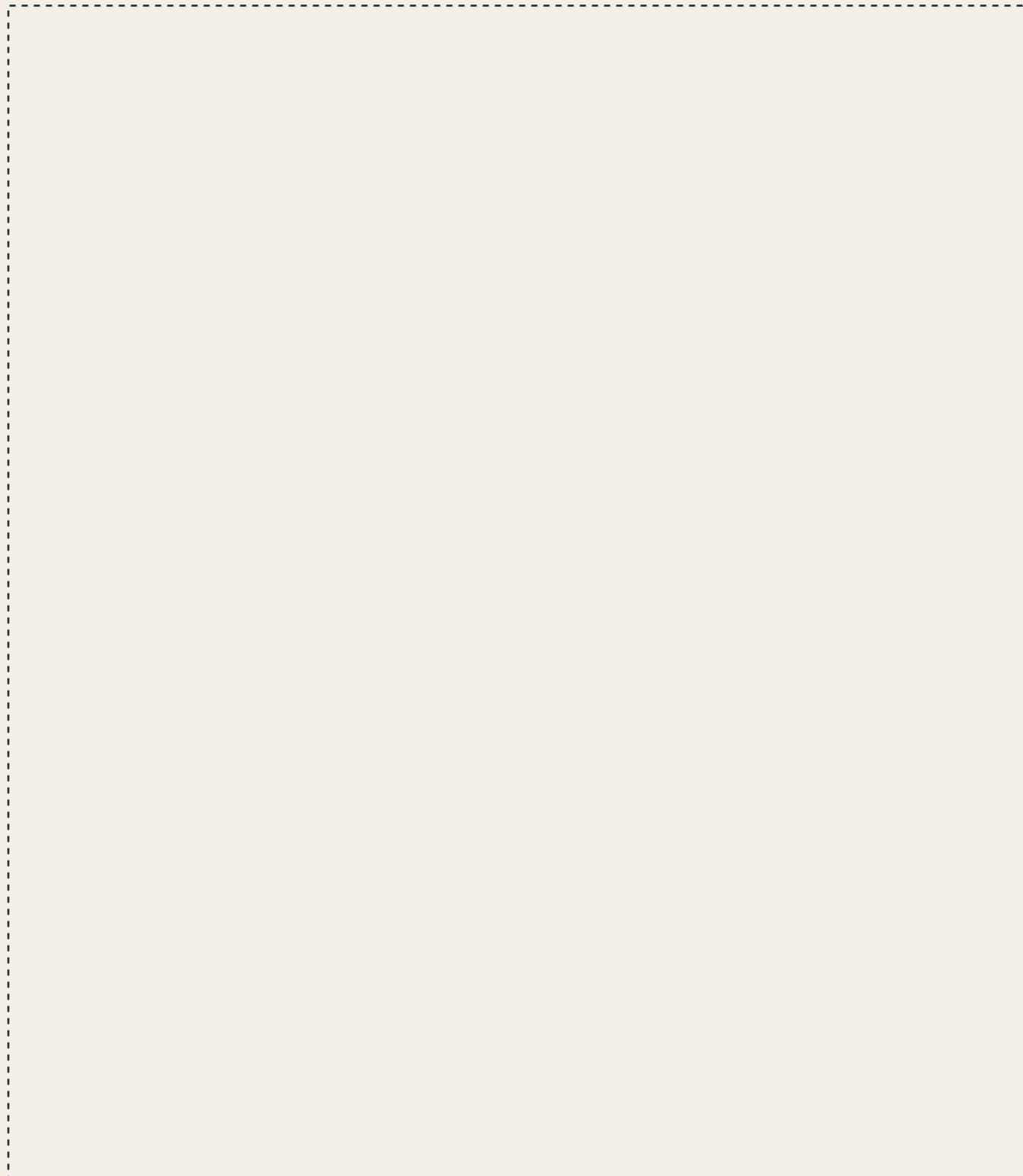
...and from that day on, the town clock ran exactly one minute fast, on purpose.



...which is how a snail ended up winning the race after all.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

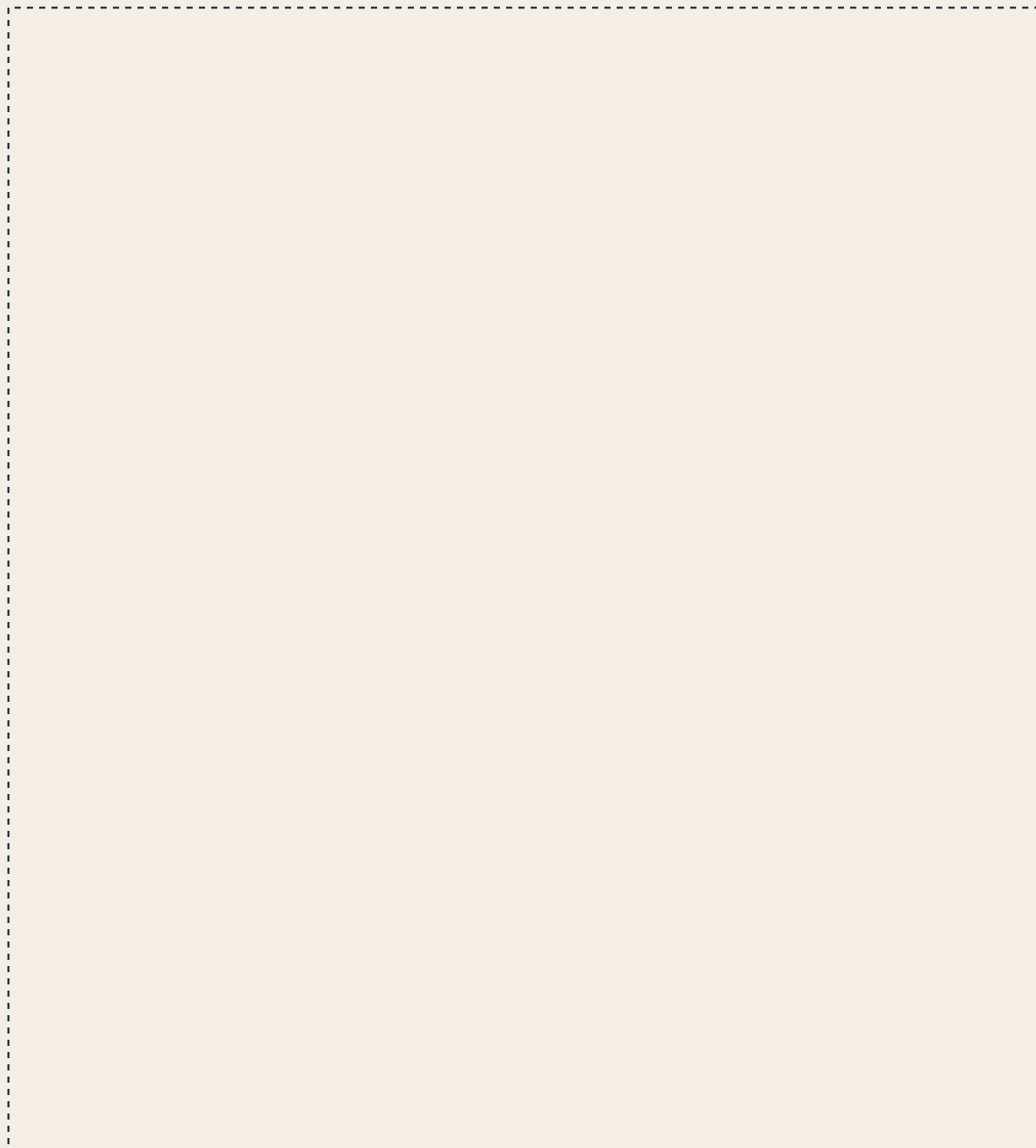
...and somewhere, a very old turtle finally exhaled.



...but by then the whole class had already learned to whistle in reverse.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

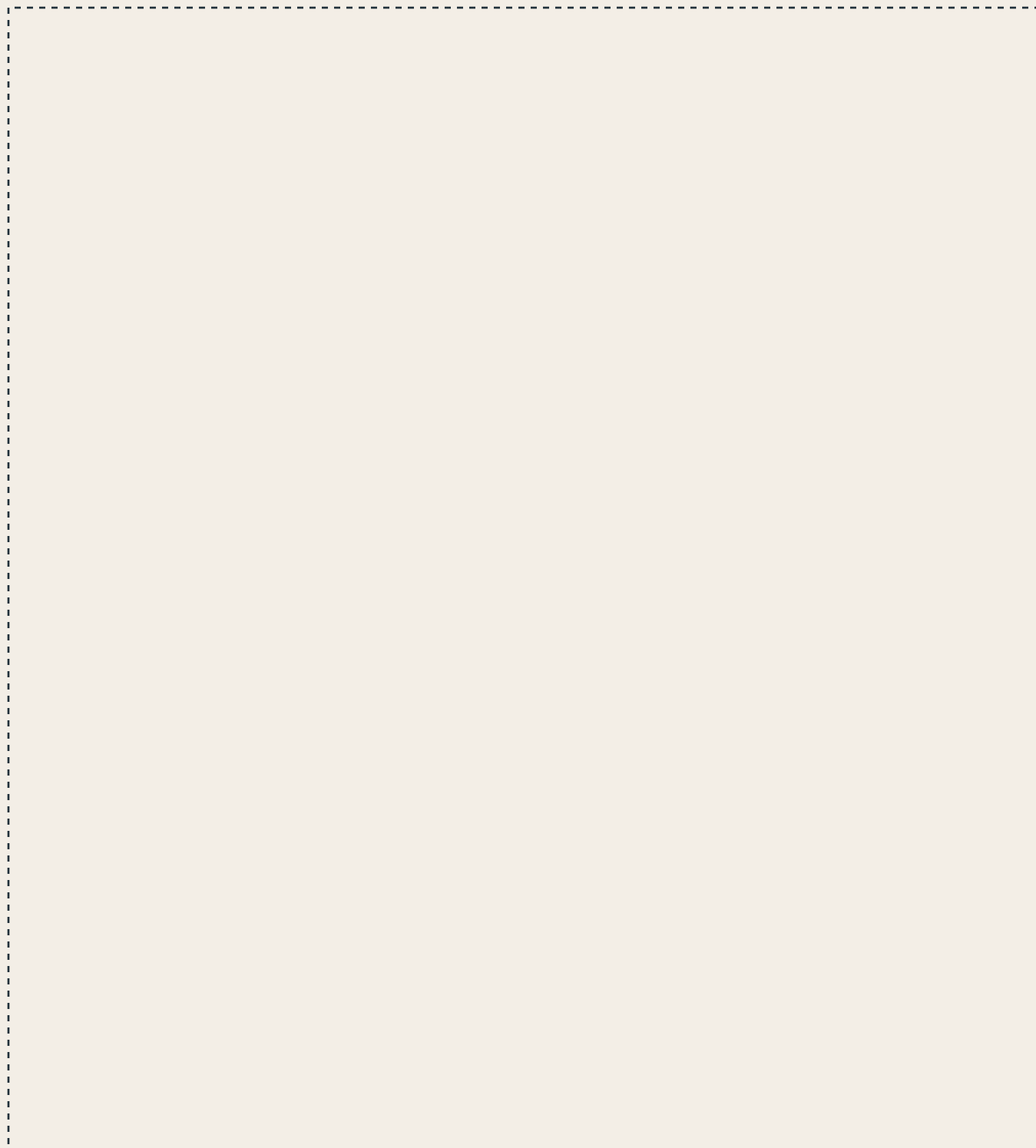
**...and the letter was never sent, because by morning it
wasn't needed anymore.**



...which is why the lake still won't freeze all the way, not even in January.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

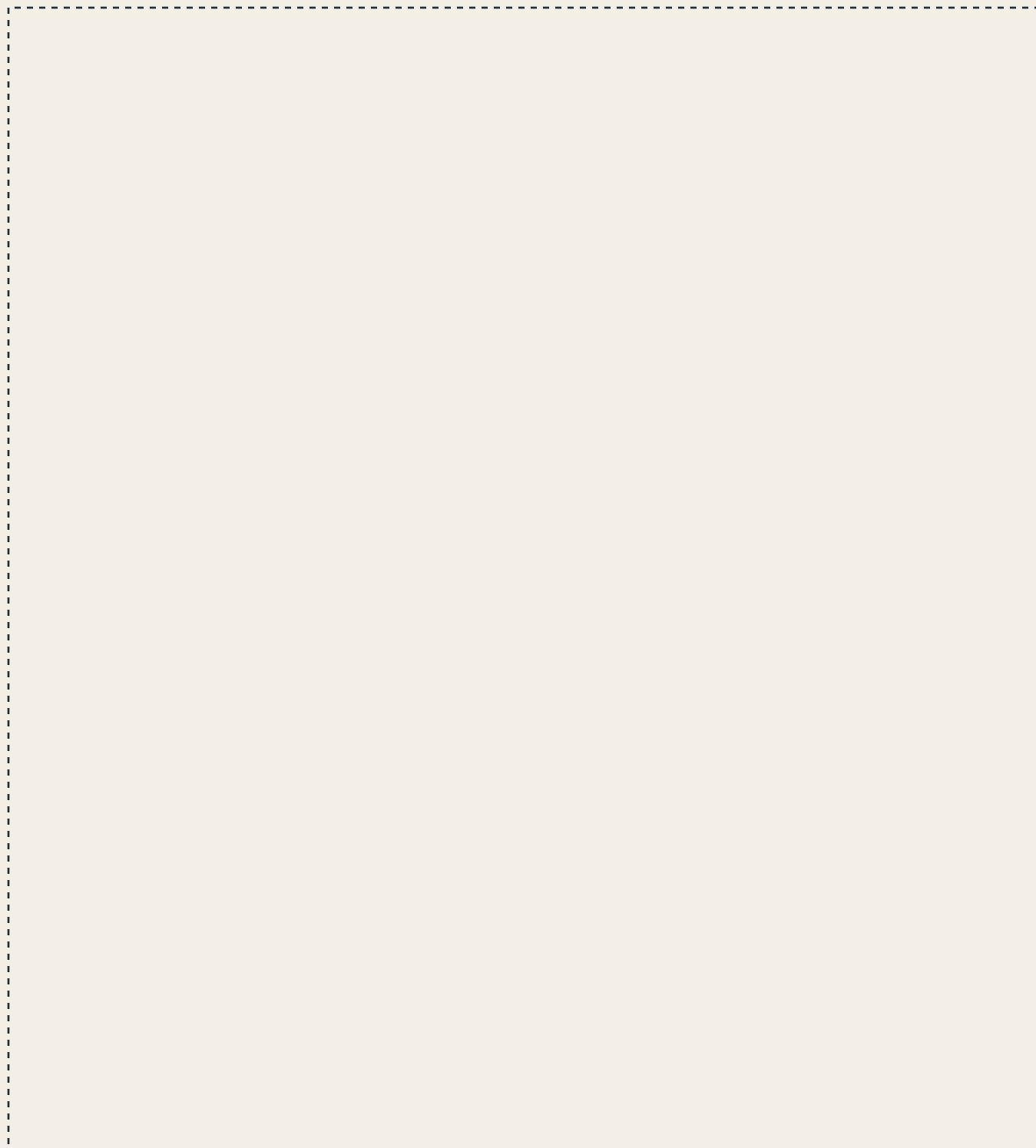
**...and the last thing the robot said was 'tell them I
liked the rain.'**



...so the map was folded up and put back exactly where it had been found.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

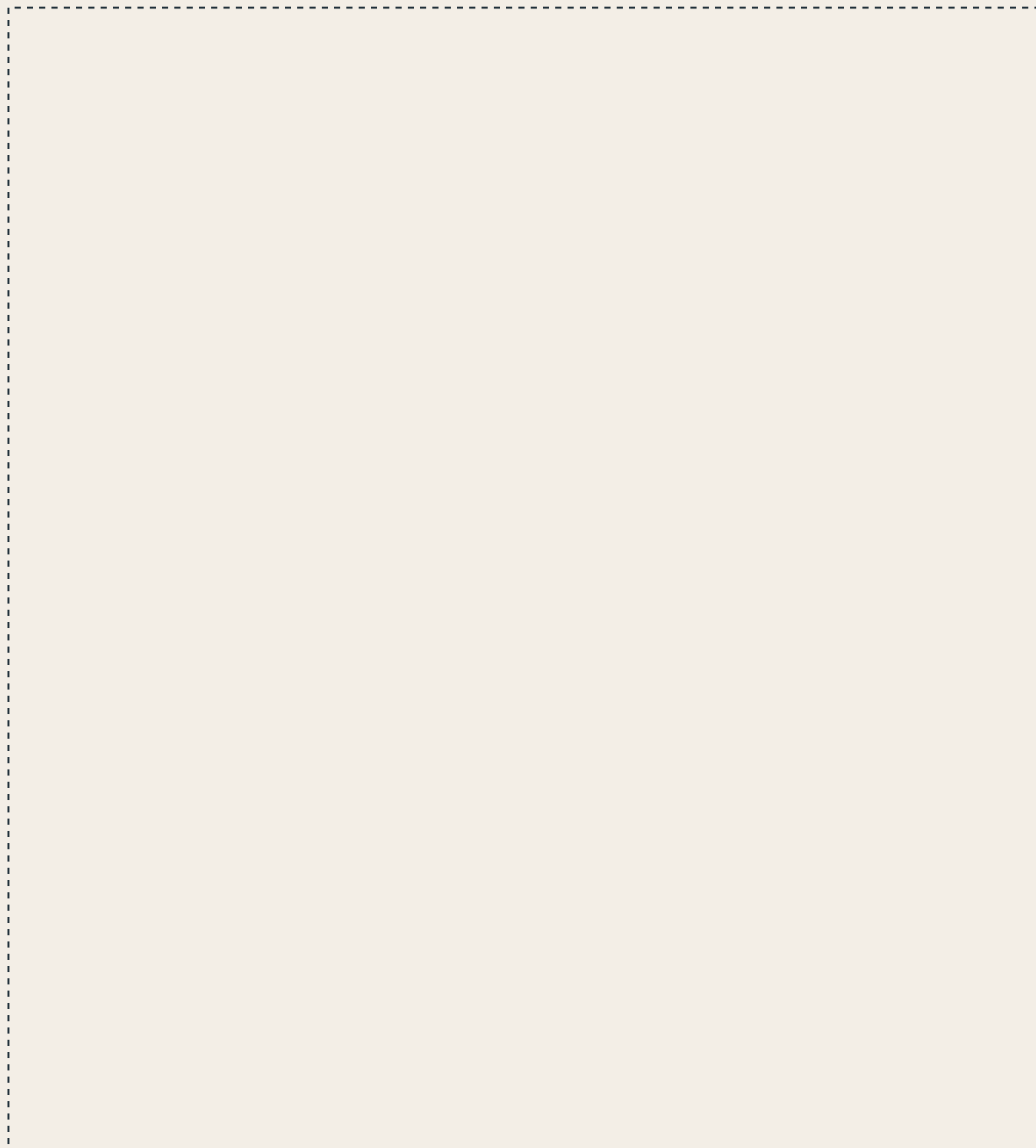
...and nobody at the party ever figured out who brought the extra chair.



...which is a strange way to become mayor, but not the strangest way it's happened.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

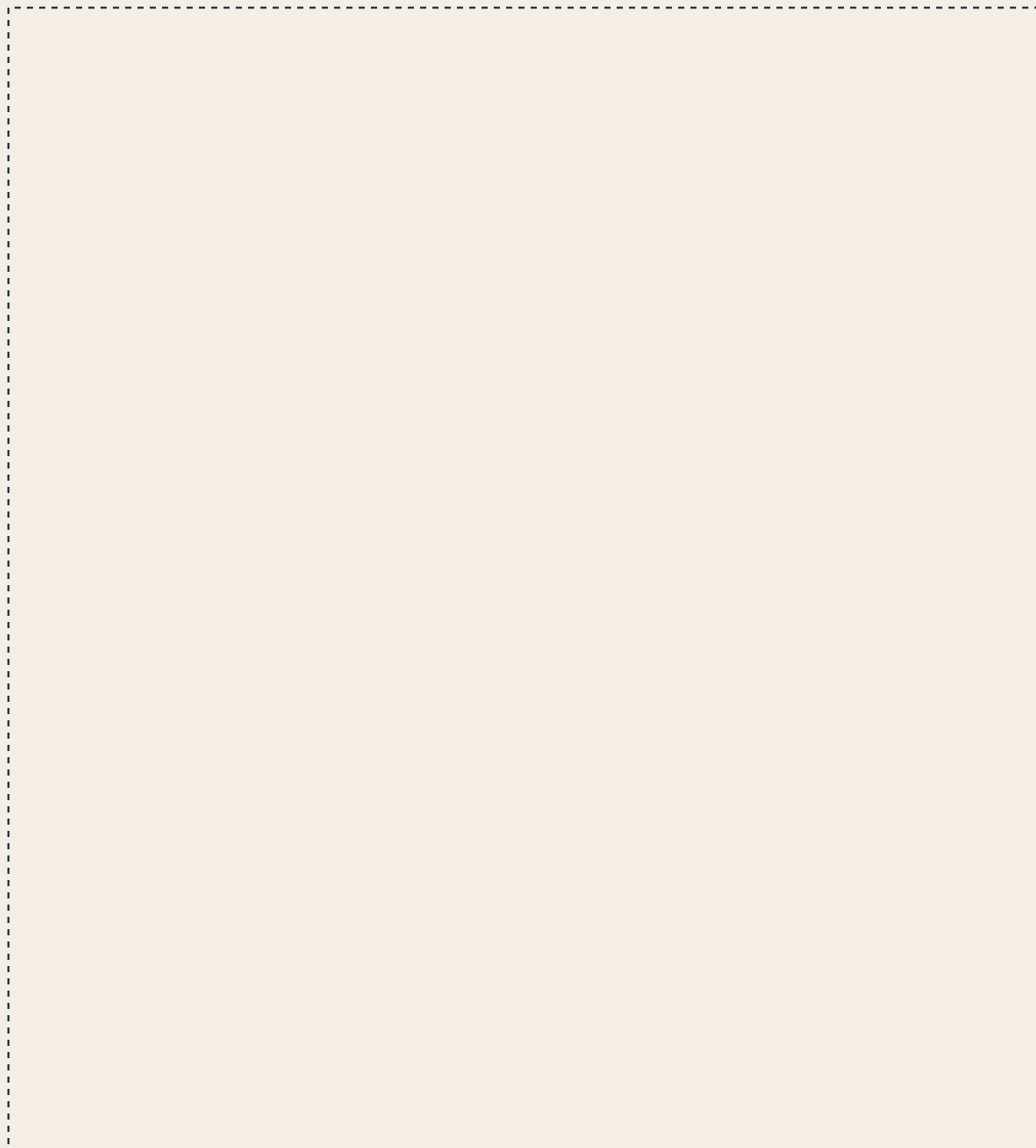
...and the garden kept growing, quietly, in a shape that
looked a little like a promise.



...so she kept the second heartbeat a secret, for now.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

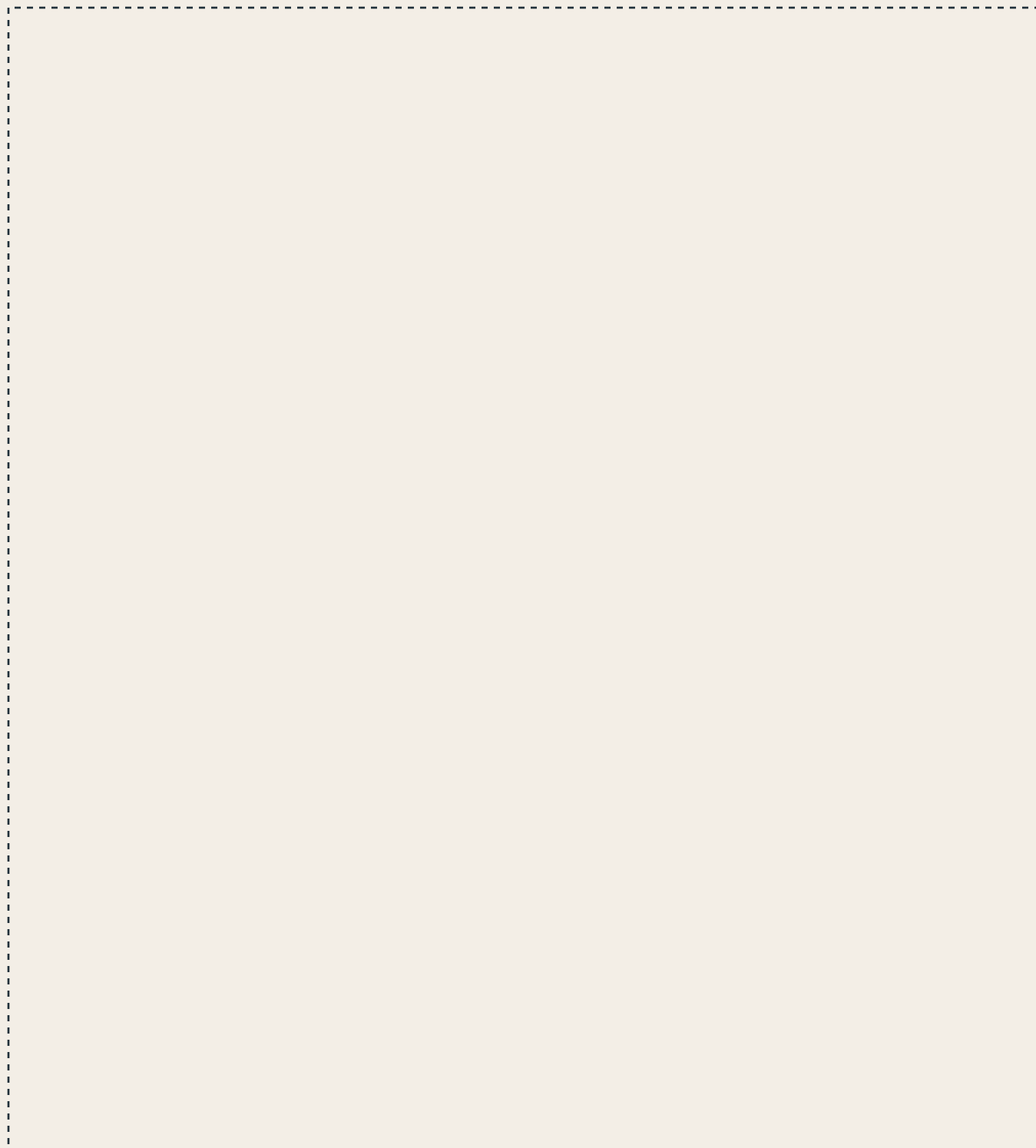
...and that was the last anyone heard the house creak on purpose.



...which meant the treasure had been under the welcome mat the entire time.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

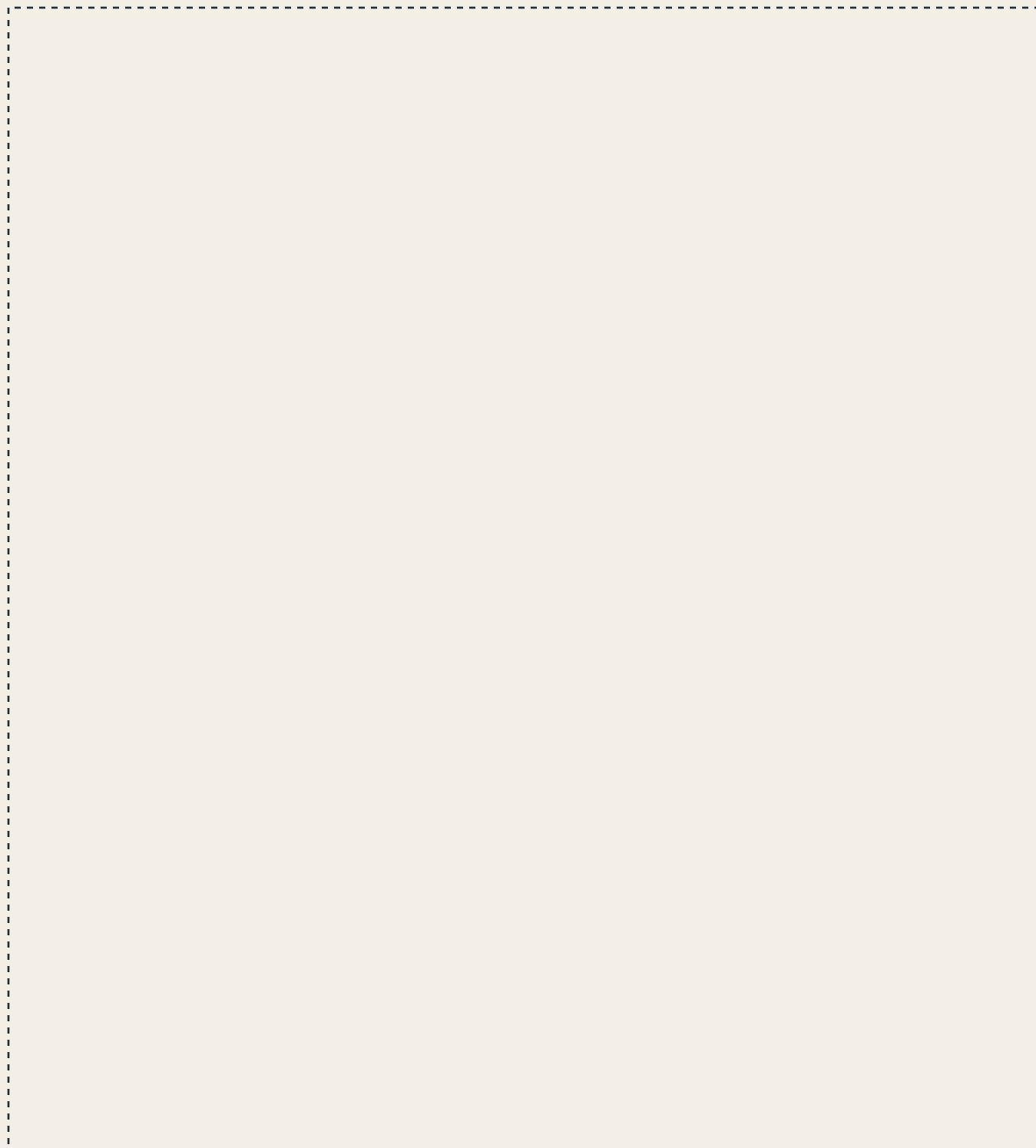
...and the stars, for once, seemed to be paying close attention.



...so the twins switched places one more time, just to see if anyone would notice.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

...and the whole ocean, just for a moment, went completely still.



20 PROMPTS · IMPOSSIBLE SITUATIONS

IMPOSSIBLE SITUATIONS

Whatever the rule is, follow it seriously.

Your shadow starts arriving five minutes before you do. Write about the first time it's late instead.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

You can hear color, but only on Tuesdays. Describe the loudest color you've ever heard.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

Your school requires all homework to be turned in as paper airplanes. Write about the day the wind changes everything.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

You wake up and your left hand only speaks a language nobody else knows. Write the first thing it tells you.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

Gravity takes weekends off in your town. Write about Saturday morning breakfast.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Every lie you tell turns into a small, harmless butterfly that follows you around. Write about the day you decide to stop lying — or don't.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

You find a door in your closet that only opens to yesterday. Write about what you go back to fix, or not fix.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Your reflection has started making different choices than you. Write about the day you finally disagree out loud.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

You can trade one memory for one wish, but you have to pick the memory blind. Write about what you're willing to lose.

[illegible]

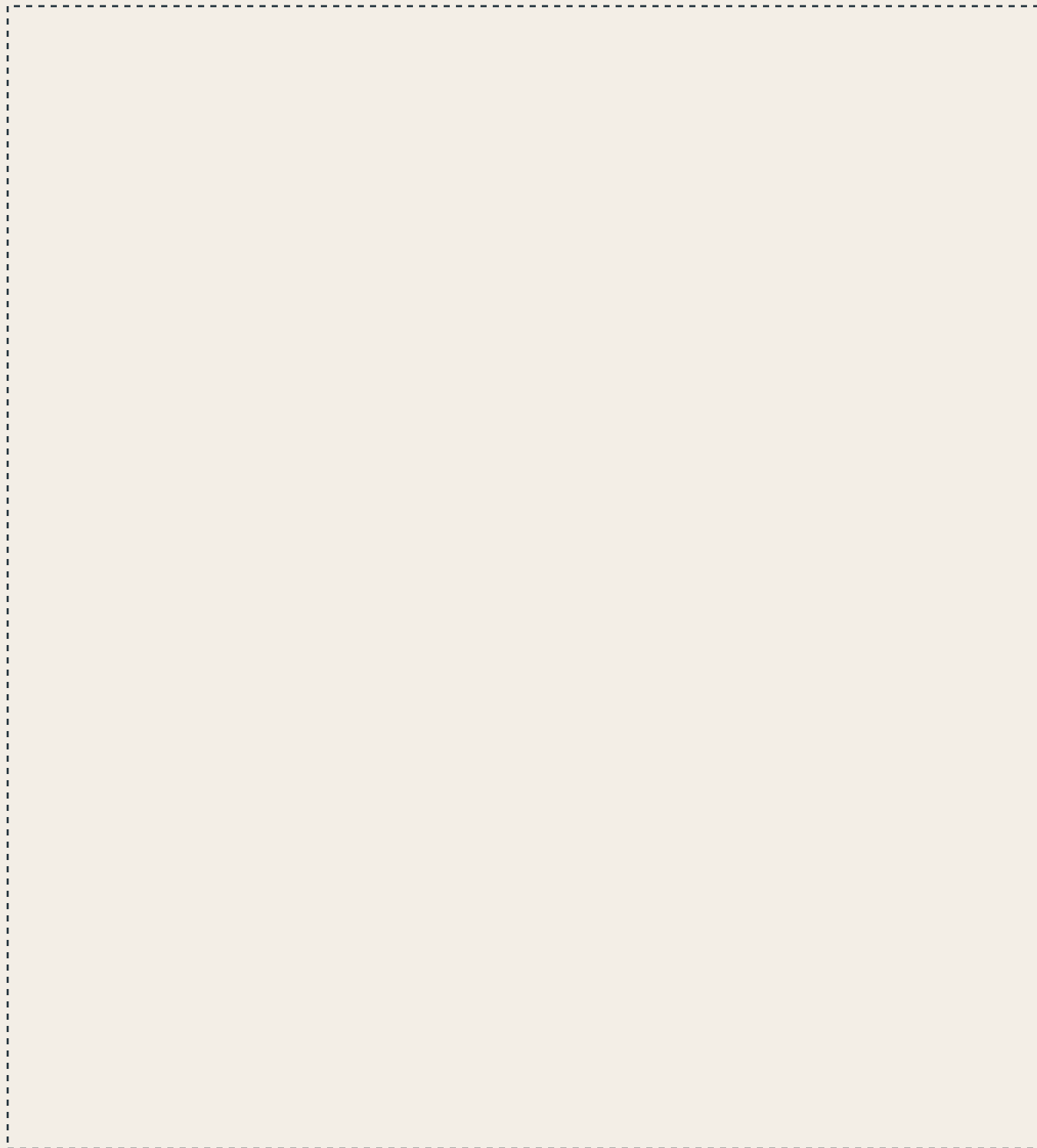
The moon is your school's newest exchange student. Write about its first day.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the student to write their response to the prompt.

Every time you tell the truth, a plant grows somewhere in the world. Write about the forest you've planted without knowing it.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

**You've discovered your pet has been keeping a journal.
Write the entry about you.**

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their journal entry.

Your town votes on the weather every Monday. Write about the week democracy goes very wrong.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

You can only time-travel by sneezing, and you never know how far. Write about where the last sneeze sent you.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

The library's overdue books have started returning themselves — with notes. Write the strangest note.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

You've inherited a house that gets one room bigger every full moon. Write about the room that appeared last night.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

Your best friend turns out to be extremely good at a skill they've never once mentioned. Write the moment you find out.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

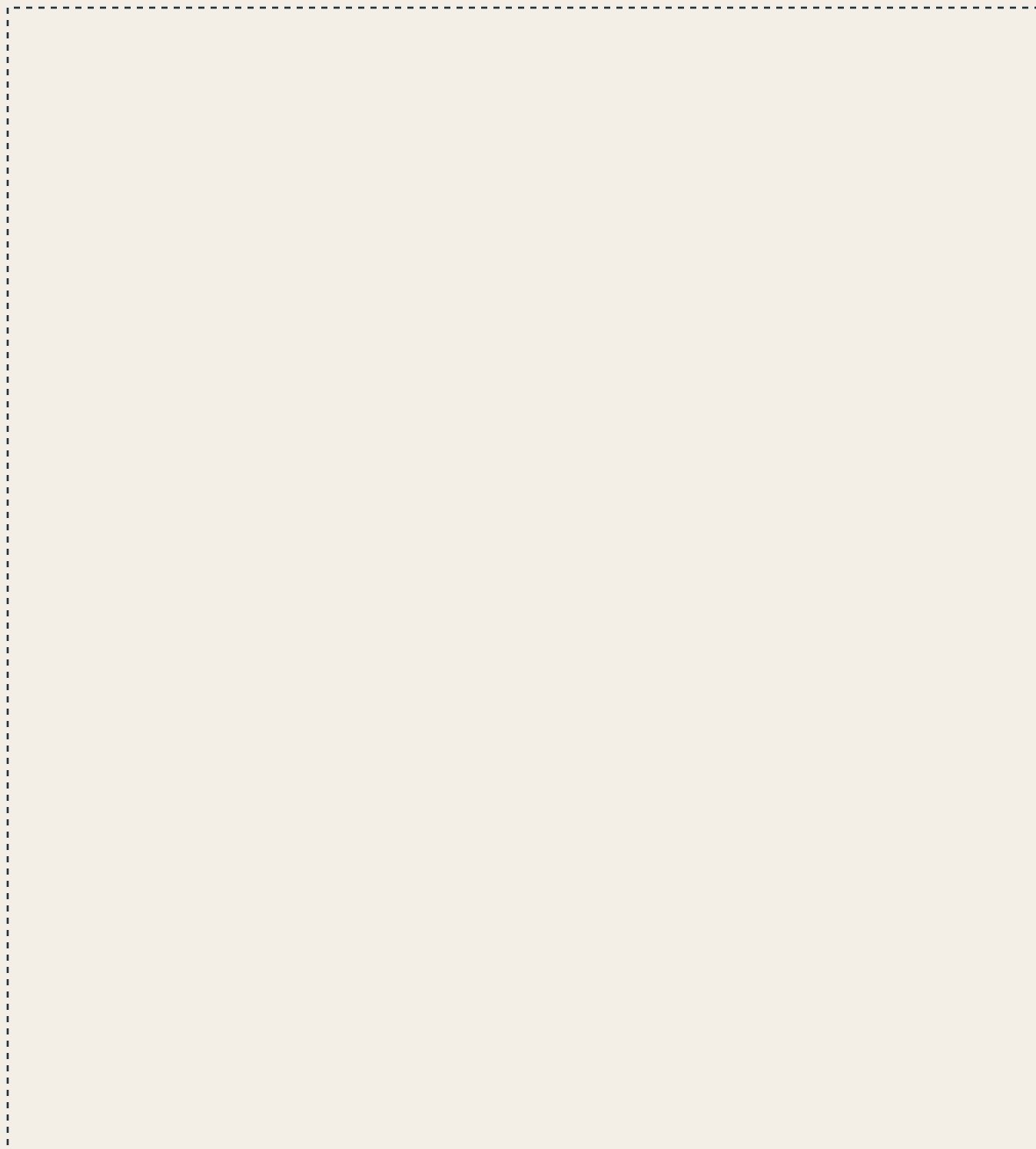
In your family, nobody is allowed to say the number seven out loud. Write about the day someone almost breaks the rule.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

You can understand what plants are thinking, but only the annoyed ones. Write about the angriest houseplant in town.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Somebody left you a message carved into the inside of a watermelon. Write what it says and who you think left it.

A large, empty rectangular box with a dashed border, intended for the user to write their response to the prompt.

BONUS

FINISH THIS STORY

Three openings. You write the rest.

The Clockmaker's Apprentice

Every apprentice who worked for old Master Renn learned the same rule on their first day: never wind the green clock. It didn't tell time -- nobody knew what it told, only that its hands moved backward on stormy nights and sat perfectly still on calm ones. Petra had kept the rule for three years, sweeping sawdust and oiling gears, until the morning she arrived to find the shop empty, the green clock ticking loudly for the first time she'd ever heard it tick, and a note pinned to the workbench in Master Renn's careful handwriting: 'Wind it. I'll explain when I'm back. If I'm not back by sundown, wind it twice.' The sun was already halfway down.

...The Clockmaker's Apprentice, continued

[illegible]

The Uninvited Guest

The dinner table was set for six, which was strange, because there were only five people in the Alvarez family, and nobody could remember setting the extra place. Nana insisted it had always been there, for as long as she could recall, though she couldn't say why. Every night the sixth plate sat empty, until the night the porch light flickered three times and somebody -- something -- knocked twice, waited, and knocked once more, exactly the way Grandpa used to.

...The Uninvited Guest, continued

This image shows a full page of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page, typical of notebook paper. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the page.

Cartography

The new kid unfolded a map on the cafeteria table and said, very calmly, that it was a map of the school, except it showed four hallways that didn't exist. When Dev pointed out the mistake, the new kid just shrugged and said the map wasn't wrong, the school was just being modest. That afternoon, chasing a rumor and a hunch, Dev found the first hallway exactly where the map said it would be -- tucked behind the janitor's closet, lit by a window that shouldn't have had anything on the other side of it.

...Cartography, continued

[illegible]